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Ordinary Tuesdays (Factory Ready)

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FRONT MATTER

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ORDINARY TUESDAYS

E.Q. Rothwell

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One: The Expensive Cereal

The cereal aisle at the Winn-Dixie on Airline Highway had a way of making Simone feel like she was standing in front of a jury.

Not a real jury. A jury of boxes. Sixty feet of them, floor to eye level, every mascot looking a little too pleased with itself, and somewhere in the middle of all that cardboard optimism, the two contenders: the store brand, \$2.79, a rooster on the front doing something that could generously be called a wink, and the name brand, \$5.49, doing nothing but sitting there being exactly what it was, twice.

"Zay. Baby. It's the same cereal."

"It's not the same cereal."

"It is chemically the same cereal. I read the ingredients one time when you weren't looking."

Isaiah did not dignify this with a response right away. He had the particular stillness of a ten-year-old who knew he was right and was choosing, out of some deep well of restraint she hoped he'd keep into adulthood, not to gloat about it yet. He picked up the name brand box, turned it so the nutrition label faced her like evidence, and said, "Fourteen grams of sugar. Store brand's got

sixteen."

"That's not - that's not the argument you think it is."

"I'm just saying the expensive one's healthier and you're about to argue with a nutrition fact."

She had, in fact, been about to argue with a nutrition fact. She closed her mouth.

This was the thing about Isaiah that nobody warned you about when they told you motherhood would be humbling. They warned you about the tantrums, the tiredness, the way your whole heart would now be walking around outside your body eating goldfish crackers off the floor of a Honda. Nobody warned you that somewhere around age nine, the child developed the ability to construct an argument, and that you - a grown woman who got paid actual money to construct arguments for a living - would occasionally lose to him in a grocery store.

She looked at the two boxes. She looked at her phone, at the banking app she'd pulled up out of habit while they'd been standing there, the number in the corner that she'd already done the math on twice this week and gotten a different, equally bad answer both times.

Two dollars and seventy cents. That was the actual distance between the rooster and the astronaut. Two-seventy was not going to be the thing that saved her. Two-seventy also was not nothing, not this month, not with the light bill sitting on the counter at home unopened like it might resolve itself if she just gave it enough silence.

"Fine," she said. "But this is a one-time thing. We are not

becoming a household that buys the expensive cereal."

"We're not becoming anything. We're just getting it this once." He said this with the easy confidence of a person who had heard "one-time thing" from her approximately four hundred times and understood it, correctly, as a category rather than a rule.

She put the astronaut in the cart.

He didn't say thank you, exactly. He said, "You want to know something weird?" already moving on, already three thoughts past the cereal, walking backward down the aisle with his hand trailing along the shelf edge the way he did, touching everything, tasting the world with his fingertips.

"Always."

"If you could only smell foods and not taste them, would you rather lose smell or taste?"

"That's not weird, that's just Tuesday for you."

"I'm serious. Because smell is like eighty percent of taste, I read that, so if you lost smell you'd basically lose taste too, so really the question is do you want to lose one sense or two senses that are secretly the same sense."

"I want to lose the sense that makes you ask me questions like this in a grocery store."

He grinned at her, the specific grin that was his father's grin, worn on a face that was otherwise entirely her own family's face, Odessa's nose and her grandmother's forehead and something underneath it all that was just Isaiah, unclaimed by anybody, brand new. He was already turning down the next aisle to campaign for a

specific brand of string cheese with the same intensity he'd brought to the cereal, and she followed him, and did the thing she always did in this store, which was let the list in her hand become a suggestion instead of a document.

By the time they got to the register she had the cereal, the string cheese, chicken because it was the cheapest protein that wasn't beans two nights in a row, and the last-minute impulse thing she always regretted and never regretted, a candle from the end cap that smelled like something called "Louisiana Porch" which was not a smell but she bought it every time anyway because some nights you needed the store to promise you a version of your own life that felt a little more finished than the one you were living.

The cashier was somebody's cousin. In Baton Rouge everybody was somebody's cousin, six ways removed, and this one - Simone thought her name might be Trish, or might be married to a Trish, the genealogy of it escaped her - rang up the cereal and said, without looking up, "That the good stuff. My grandbaby won't touch nothing else."

"He convinced me it's healthier."

"It ain't." Trish, or Trish-adjacent, scanned the string cheese. "But it's good, so."

Simone laughed, actually laughed, the first unguarded sound she'd made since 6 a.m., and Isaiah looked up at her like the laugh had surprised him too, like he'd caught her doing something private in public.

In the car, she did the math again. She always did the math in the parking lot, engine not yet on, both hands still on the wheel like

she was about to drive somewhere instead of sit there subtracting things. The light bill. The invoice from the Hebert account that was now eleven days late, which Renata had mentioned in the group email that morning in that particular tone Renata had, the tone that managed to say I told you this would happen without technically saying anything at all. The two-seventy, which was nothing, which was also somehow the exact weight of everything else.

If she just got more disciplined about this. That was the thought, the one she reached for the way you reach for a doorknob in a dark room, not because you're sure it's the right door but because your hand already knows the shape of it. If she made a real budget and stuck to it. If she stopped letting Isaiah win the cereal argument. If she got up at five instead of five-forty and used that extra time to get ahead of the invoicing instead of lying there for six minutes first, doing the thing she did every morning where she listed the day's problems in her head like she was taking inventory before the store opened.

She was thirty-four years old and she still believed, somewhere under the part of her brain that had read every productivity book Odessa's church friends passed around, that the solution to almost anything was more discipline. That if she just tightened the grip a little more, the whole apparatus of her life - the business, the bills, the boy in the backseat currently narrating an entire imaginary basketball game under his breath - would stop feeling like something she was holding together with two hands and start feeling like something that simply held.

"Mama."

"Hm."

"You're doing the face."

"What face."

"The math face. You do it in the parking lot every time." He said this without judgment, the way you'd note the weather. "We got the cereal. It's fine."

"I know it's fine, baby."

"Then why the face."

She looked at him in the rearview mirror, seven years old going on forty, forty going on seven, already back to his imaginary basketball game before she'd even answered, already moved on the way ten-year-olds moved on, completely, mercifully, unburdened by whatever she was carrying that he had just, without meaning to, correctly named.

"It's not a face," she said, and started the car. "It's my thinking face."

"It's the math face," Isaiah said again, cheerfully, already gone, already three thoughts ahead, and she pulled out of the parking lot with the astronaut cereal riding shotgun in a bag at his feet, thinking that she would fix this. Whatever this was. She would get disciplined about it, whatever it was, and it would stop showing up on her face in parking lots where ten-year-olds could read it like a headline.

She did not think, because it had not yet occurred to her to think it, that the face had nothing to do with cereal, or math, or discipline at all.

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Chapter Two: The Wi-Fi Password

The kitchen table had become an office sometime around eight months ago, the way a room does that without anyone deciding it, just one document at a time until there's no tablecloth anymore, only a laptop and a coffee mug doing double duty as a pen cup and a stack of folders color-coded in a system that made sense to nobody but her.

Tonight it was the deck. The one for Thursday. Twelve slides that were supposed to explain, in language a bank would find reassuring, why Ascend was worth a second look after the numbers from Q2 had come in looking like a question mark instead of an answer. She had four hours before Isaiah's bedtime and roughly forty minutes of actual thinking behind her, which was the part nobody told you about working from a kitchen table in a house with a ten-year-old in it - that the clock and the actual usable time inside the clock were two entirely different currencies, and you were always broke in the second one no matter how rich you were in the first.

"Mama."

"Mm-hm."

"What's the Wi-Fi password."

"It's the same as it's been for two years, baby."

"I forgot it."

"You did not forget it. You typed it into your tablet four hundred times."

"The tablet logged me out."

She did not look up from the slide, which had a chart on it that had looked confident an hour ago and now looked, the longer she stared at it, like it was hiding something from her, the way numbers sometimes did when you'd been awake too many consecutive hours to trust your own subtraction.

"Isaiah."

"It's on the router, right, it's the sticker, but somebody" - a pause that told her exactly who the somebody was - "peeled part of the sticker off so it just says 'Sunfl' and then nothing."

She closed her eyes. Sunflower447. Odessa's suggestion, from the year Odessa had gone through a phase of naming everything after her garden, the router and the WiFi and, briefly, one deeply confused Roomba.

"It's Sunflower, capital S, four seven."

"Sunflower like the flower?"

"Like the flower."

"That's a weird password."

"Your grandmother picked it."

"Figures." He was gone again, footsteps retreating down the hall with the specific unhurried confidence of a child who has gotten what he came for and doesn't understand that he's taken anything from anyone in the getting of it.

She got four more minutes into the slide before he was back.

"It's not working."

"Did you capitalize the S?"

"I don't know, I just typed it."

"Isaiah, you have to capitalize the S."

"You didn't say that the first time."

"I said capital S the first time."

"You said it fast."

She looked up at him then, really looked, the way you look at someone when you're deciding whether the next sentence out of your mouth is going to be fair or is just going to be tired wearing a fair sentence's clothes. He was standing in the doorway in the shirt he'd worn to school, hair doing the thing it did by eight p.m. that no amount of morning effort could prevent, tablet held against his chest like a shield, and underneath the mild outrage of a boy denied his cartoons was just - a kid. A kid who wanted the internet to work so he could watch something stupid and rest his brain after a day of being ten, which was, she had to occasionally remind herself, its own kind of exhausting job.

"Capital S," she said, gentler. "Like the beginning of a sentence."

He disappeared. She got back into the deck. The chart still looked like it was hiding something. She was three sentences into a talking point about projected Q3 recovery when he was back, and this time he didn't say anything, just held the tablet toward her, screen out, the little red exclamation point that meant wrong password glowing at her like an accusation.

"You typed it wrong."

"I typed it exactly how you said."

"Let me see." She took the tablet. Typed it herself, slow, deliberate, watching each letter land. The red exclamation mark stayed exactly where it was. She tried again. Nothing.

"The Wi-Fi's down," she said, mostly to herself, already reaching for her phone to check, and there it was, the little icon in the corner that told her the whole house had lost internet forty minutes ago and she hadn't noticed because she'd been working off her own hotspot, burning through data she couldn't really spare this close to the billing cycle, on a chart that still looked wrong.

"So it's not the password."

"It's not the password."

"You made me try it like six times."

"I didn't know it was the router, Isaiah, I was working."

"You're always working."

He said it the way kids say true things, without weight, without meaning to make it land anywhere in particular, already turning to go find something else to do with the hour he'd now lost to a router that would need resetting, and it was such an ordinary sentence, such a completely unremarkable ten-year-old complaint, that she was surprised by how much room it took up in her chest on its way through.

"I'm not always working."

"You're working right now."

"I have a deck due Thursday."

"You always have a deck due Thursday." He wasn't even looking

at her when he said it, already halfway down the hall, already thinking about something else, the sentence just a thing he'd tossed over his shoulder the way he tossed his backpack by the door, no aim behind it, no intent to wound, which was somehow worse than if he'd meant it, because it meant it was simply true enough to have become furniture. A fact of the house. Like the squeaky wheel on the cart she always ended up with at the Winn-Dixie, the one she noticed every single time and never once traded out for a different cart, because by the time she noticed it she was already three items deep into the list and it didn't seem worth the stop.

She sat there for a second with her hand still on the router, unplugged now, waiting the thirty seconds it needed before she could plug it back in, and something about standing in her own kitchen holding a small unplugged box, waiting for it to be ready to try again, felt like it meant something she didn't have the two extra minutes to figure out.

"Zay."

He reappeared in the doorway, tablet already tucked under his arm in anticipation, the universal ten-year-old posture of a kid who has learned that adults sometimes call you back to apologize and has developed a certain patience for waiting it out.

"I'm sorry I got short with you."

"It's fine."

"It's not - I shouldn't have snapped like that. The Wi-Fi being down isn't your fault."

"I know." He shrugged, already bored of the apology, which was its own kind of mercy, the way kids let you off the hook faster than

you let yourself off it. "Can I have a snack while it resets."

"Yeah, baby. Get a snack."

He went. She plugged the router back in and watched the lights blink through their sequence, amber to green, and sat back down in front of the slide that still, even now, looked like it was hiding something from her, though she was starting to suspect the thing it was hiding wasn't in the numbers at all.

You're always working, he'd said, no weight behind it, and she found herself doing the thing she did with client feedback, turning it over for the actionable part, the fixable part. More boundaries. A real cutoff time. Maybe the thing was she needed to close the laptop at seven sharp regardless of what wasn't finished, build the discipline of a hard stop the way the productivity books talked about, protect the evening the way you'd protect anything worth protecting.

She wrote 7pm cutoff - non-negotiable on the sticky note by her elbow, underlined it twice, and went back to the chart, not noticing that the note went in the same pile as six other notes just like it, promises to a version of the evening that never quite arrived, and did not ask herself, because it had not yet occurred to her to ask, whether the problem was really the hour on the clock, or something underneath the hour that no cutoff time was going to touch.

Down the hall, she could hear the tablet chime back to life, the small triumphant fanfare of a video loading, and Isaiah's voice, satisfied, talking to nobody. "Finally."

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Chapter Three: Miss Pearline's Porch

Miss Pearline's porch had a particular quality of shade to it in the evening, the kind that made a person's shoulders drop half an inch without them noticing, and Simone had never once in her adult life walked past that house on a Tuesday without getting called up onto it.

"Girl, I see you trying to sneak by."

"I wasn't sneaking, Miss Pearline, I was walking with purpose."

"That's what sneaking looks like when a grown woman does it." Pearline was in the same chair she was always in, the one with the cushion gone flat as a pancake from forty years of evenings, a glass of sweet tea sweating a ring onto the little table beside her, and she patted the empty rocker next to hers with the flat certainty of a woman who had already decided Simone was sitting down whether Simone had decided it yet or not.

Simone sat. Isaiah had already peeled off toward the Robicheaux boy's yard two houses down, where a basketball hoop with no net was somehow more compelling than every device in their own house combined, and for a minute the two women just sat there with the sound of a lawnmower somewhere down the block and a mosquito truck making its slow evening pass three streets over.

"You look tired," Pearline said. It wasn't unkind. It was just accurate, the way Pearline's observations tended to be, sanded down over decades until they didn't have any edges left to soften.

"I'm building something. Building things is tired work."

"Mm." Pearline took a sip of her tea. "Your mama used to say the same thing. Every single week. I'm building something, Pearline." She said it in a voice that was doing a passable, slightly cruel impression of Odessa, and Simone laughed before she could stop herself. "She was building a household, though. You out here building a - what is it you call it."

"A company, Miss Pearline. Ascend."

"Ascend." Pearline turned the word over like she was checking it for damage. "Ascend to where."

"That's the pitch, actually."

"I don't need the pitch, baby, I need to know if you're eating."

"I'm eating."

"Uh-huh." Pearline didn't believe her, and didn't say so, which was its own kind of believing. "You know what got me through raising two children by myself with a husband who wasn't worth the gas it took him to leave? Discipline. Not feelings. Discipline. You get up, you do the thing, you don't wait to feel like doing the thing, because feeling like it is a luxury item, baby, and you were not born with the coupon for it."

Simone felt something in her chest settle at that, the specific relief of hearing a hard thing said plainly by somebody who'd survived it. This was the sermon she came here for, whether she knew it walking up the driveway or not - the reminder that the answer was grip, was will, was getting up before you felt like it and doing the thing anyway. She filed it, the way she filed everything useful, in the place in her mind labeled things I need to do more of.

"I hear you," she said. "I do. I think I've just gotten soft about my mornings."

"Soft mornings make hard years." Pearline nodded at her own line, pleased with it, and reached over to swat at a mosquito that had gotten too ambitious. "Discipline, Simone. It's not glamorous but it's the whole thing. Ask anybody who ever built anything that lasted."

"Did discipline build this porch?"

"Discipline built this house. The porch was extra."

They sat with that a minute, and Simone almost let it go, almost let the conversation drift on toward the Robicheaux boy's questionable jump shot or the price of shrimp at the Rouses on Perkins, but something in her, some small automatic curiosity that had nothing to do with strategy, made her ask the thing she asked sometimes without entirely meaning to.

"You ever wish you'd built something different? Something just for you?"

Pearline's face did a thing then, quick, there and gone, like a cloud passing over a yard and leaving it exactly as sunny as before, except the grass remembered, somehow, that it had been shaded for a second.

"I built a daughter," Pearline said. "That was mine. That was just for me." She took a sip of tea that lasted a beat too long. "Course she's in Houston now. Doesn't call as much as houses that get built are supposed to call." She said it lightly, the way you'd mention a bill you'd already paid, and then, before Simone could follow the thread anywhere, Pearline was up and out of it, waving a hand like

she was clearing smoke. "Anyway. That's an old story, and this tea is getting warm, and I believe that is the Robicheaux boy about to break his arm trying to dunk on a hoop that doesn't even have a net, Lord help him."

Simone looked down the street. Isaiah was indeed hanging off the rim like a much smaller, much less coordinated professional athlete, shrieking with a joy that had nothing to do with whether the shot had gone in.

"He's gonna break something one day," Simone said.

"They mostly don't," Pearline said. "And when they do, it heals. That's the part nobody tells you when they're small - they mostly heal fine. It's you that carries the memory of the crack."

Simone laughed, because it was funny, the way Pearline's wisdom always came wrapped in something that could double as a joke if you didn't look at it too directly. She stayed another twenty minutes, long enough to hear an update on the Broussard divorce two streets over and an extended, unprompted review of a preacher's sermon from three Sundays back that Pearline was still, evidently, working through some disagreements with. By the time she called Isaiah in, the shade on the porch had gone from generous to total, the streetlights stuttering on one by one down the block.

"You good, baby?" Pearline asked, as Simone stood to go, and there was something in the way she asked it, some small residual weight left over from the daughter in Houston, that Simone noticed and didn't examine, the way you notice a picture is slightly crooked on a wall you're only passing through.

"I'm good, Miss Pearline. Just gotta get more disciplined about my mornings."

"That's the whole thing," Pearline said, satisfied, settling back into her flattened cushion like a woman closing a book she'd read a hundred times and still liked the ending of. "Get up. Do the thing. Don't wait to feel like it."

Simone walked home with Isaiah recounting, in exhaustive detail, every single one of his eleven missed dunk attempts, and somewhere in the recounting she found herself already drafting the new morning schedule in her head - five a.m., not five-forty, thirty extra minutes of pure discipline before the day could get its hands on her - filing Pearline's sermon in the same drawer as all the others, certain, the whole walk home, that she'd finally found the missing piece, and never once wondering what it might have cost a woman to build that particular sermon out of a daughter who didn't call.

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CHAPTER 4

Chapter Four: Neecy Shows Up Unannounced

Neecy didn't knock so much as announce herself through the door, which she did approximately four seconds after Simone heard her car - a Charger with a muffler that had given up trying - pull into the driveway like it was late for something urgent, which it never was.

"Girl, put some shoes on, we going to that new spot on Government Street, they got a band tonight, some boy from Neecy's cousin's wedding is playing bass, I told him we'd come."

"It's a Tuesday."

"It's a Tuesday you're gonna remember instead of one you're not." Neecy was already in the kitchen, already opening the fridge like she paid rent there, already narrating her disapproval of its contents. "Simone. There is nothing in here but string cheese and a sad-looking rotisserie chicken."

"That chicken's not sad, that chicken's Tuesday's dinner."

"That chicken looks like it gave up." Neecy shut the fridge and turned around, hands on her hips, doing the thing she did where she took up the exact amount of space a room could hold. She'd come from work - she did billing for an orthodontist's office off College Drive, a job she complained about with the specific enthusiasm of somebody who wasn't actually going anywhere - and had not bothered to change, still had the little embroidered polo on with SMILEWORKS stitched over the pocket, tights, house slippers she'd apparently driven over in.

"I've got a deck due Thursday."

"You've always got a deck due Thursday."

"That's what Zay said."

"Zay's smarter than you some days." Neecy pulled out a chair at the table, sat down backward in it, arms crossed over the back, and looked at Simone with the specific expression she reserved for exactly this situation, the one that said she had already decided the

conversation and was just waiting for Simone to catch up to it. "Come on, Sim. One hour. You don't even have to dance, you can sit there and judge everybody's outfit like you love to do."

"I don't love to do that."

"You love it. You did it at Marcus and Denise's wedding for forty-five straight minutes, you had a whole running commentary."

"That bridesmaid dress deserved commentary."

"See, there she is." Neecy pointed at her like she'd caught something in a trap. "That's the Sim I'm trying to get out the house. Not project-manager Simone. Not deck-due-Thursday Simone. The one who used to climb out her bedroom window at sixteen to go sit on the levee and do absolutely nothing productive for three hours because it felt good."

"I was sixteen. I had no responsibilities."

"You had a curfew, which you broke, which is a kind of responsibility you were choosing not to have." Neecy grinned, pleased with her own logic, and reached over to steal a piece of the sad rotisserie chicken straight off the cutting board with her fingers. "One hour. I'll even let you leave if the bass player's bad, which, full disclosure, he might be, I've never actually heard him play, I just told him we'd come because he's cute and I panicked."

Simone laughed - really laughed, the kind that came up from somewhere lower than her throat, the kind she almost never did in front of anyone but this exact person - and something in her chest that had been clenched since roughly six that morning let go a half an inch.

"Zay doesn't have anybody to watch him."

"Zay can come. Zay loves a bad bass player, he told me so himself last time, he said and I quote, 'it's funny when they mess up.'" Neecy was already up, already pulling Simone's coat off the hook by the door and holding it out like a challenge. "Come on. You've got until Thursday for the deck. You don't got until Thursday for laughing, that expires, that's a use-it-or-lose-it thing, that's basic biology."

"That is not basic biology."

"It's basic Neecy biology, which is the only biology that matters in this house tonight."

They ended up going, all three of them, Isaiah delighted at the unexpected reprieve from bedtime, and the bass player was, in fact, bad, gloriously bad, missing a whole section of the second song so completely that the drummer just stopped and stared at him with an expression of pure betrayal, and Neecy laughed so hard she had to put her drink down, laughed with her whole body the way she'd always laughed, since they were girls, since before either of them had a single responsibility heavier than a curfew, and Simone laughed too, easily, without checking herself first, without the small internal audit she usually ran before letting a sound like that out in public.

It was somewhere in the middle of that laughing that Neecy said it - quick, sideways, half into her drink, easy to miss if you weren't the kind of person who noticed when somebody's voice dropped a register for half a sentence.

"I keep thinking I'm gonna wake up one day and just - start. Like

the actual thing. Not the billing job. The real thing." She said it lightly, so lightly it almost wasn't there, and then, before Simone could turn all the way toward it, Neecy was already laughing again, loud, waving a hand at the bass player who'd just dropped his pick entirely. "Oh my GOD, did you see that, he's not even trying anymore, this is the best hour of my whole month."

Simone meant to come back to it. She filed the sentence away the way she filed most things Neecy said that sounded like they might matter - half a thought to return to later, once Thursday's deck was behind her, once things had settled down enough to have the kind of conversation that sentence seemed to be asking for. She didn't come back to it that night. Isaiah fell asleep in the car on the way home with barbecue sauce still on his chin, and Neecy hugged her too long in the driveway the way she always did, and said, into Simone's shoulder, "Thank you for coming, I needed that," in a voice that made it sound like the bass player had been the point, and not the reason.

"Anytime, Neecy."

"Liar. You hate leaving the house."

"I don't hate it. I just have a deck due Thursday."

"Sim." Neecy pulled back, held her by both shoulders, looked at her with an expression that was mostly teasing and only a little bit serious. "You always got a deck due Thursday. One day it's gonna be a different Thursday and you still gonna say the same thing."

Simone laughed it off, kissed her cheek, told her to text when she got home, and drove the six blocks back with Isaiah asleep in the back seat and the radio down low, thinking about the deck, about

the chart that still looked like it was hiding something, about five a.m. instead of five-forty, and did not think, because it hadn't occurred to her yet to think it, about the half-second where Neecy's voice had dropped and then sped right back up before anyone could follow it there.

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CHAPTER 5

Chapter Five: The Check Bounced

The bank's text came in at 7:14 in the morning, while Simone was standing over the stove with one hand on a spatula and the other scrolling through email, which was not a safe way to cook eggs but was, lately, the only way she cooked anything.

Insufficient funds notice for account ending in 4471.

She read it twice. Then she read it a third time, as if the numbers might rearrange themselves into something less true on a third pass, the way they sometimes did in dreams, and then she turned the stove off, because the eggs were the least urgent thing happening in the kitchen now.

The Hebert payment. It had to be the Hebert payment, fourteen days late now and climbing, the one Renata had mentioned in that group email with a tone that managed to imply negligence without using the word. Simone had done the math against it, had counted on it landing by the fifth, had let the count-on turn into a plan the way she always did, one deposit doing the work of three obligations at once, and now the deposit hadn't come and the three

obligations had gone and collected themselves anyway, indifferent to her plan, the way obligations always were.

She called her mother out of habit more than strategy. Odessa picked up on the second ring, already talking.

"You're up early."

"Bank sent a notice. Insufficient funds."

There was a pause on the line, the specific Odessa pause that meant she was deciding how much restraint the moment deserved and had already decided against most of it.

"For what account."

"Business."

"Simone." Odessa said her name the way she'd said it since Simone was nine years old and had done something Odessa considered avoidable. "How many times I got to say it. That business account and your household need to be two different oceans, not two cups from the same pitcher."

"It's not - Mama, it's a timing issue, a client's late on a payment, it's happened before, it'll clear by Friday."

"It'll clear by Friday if the client pays by Friday. What if he doesn't?"

"He will."

"You said that about the Doucet account too."

"That's different."

"It is not different, it is the same exact sentence with a different

name in it." Odessa's voice had the particular flatness she got when she was right and didn't feel any need to raise her voice about it. "I told you when you started this. Get a real job with a real check that comes every two weeks whether the sun rises or not, and build the dream on the side until the dream can hold its own weight. You didn't want to hear that."

"I heard it. I just didn't agree with it."

"Well, the bank agreed with me this morning, so."

Simone stood in the kitchen with the phone against her ear and the cold eggs congealing in the pan and felt the particular anger that only her mother could produce in her, an anger built entirely out of the fact that Odessa was not wrong, had perhaps never once in Simone's adult life been wrong about a warning like this, and being right in that specific tone made the rightness feel like an accusation instead of the concern it probably, underneath everything, actually was.

"I'm not asking you to fix it, Mama. I'm handling it."

"I didn't say fix it. I said I told you."

"You always say I told you."

"Because I'm always right, and you never let me enjoy it, you just get mad at me for having said it in the first place." There was something almost like humor under that, dry as the rest of her, but Simone was too far into the morning's arithmetic to catch it. "You want to know what I did when your father passed and the insurance took eleven months to pay out? I did not wait around building a dream. I took the job at the parish office that I hated every single day for six years, because a check that comes every two weeks

doesn't care how you feel about it, and neither do two children who need shoes."

"I'm not you, Mama."

"I know you're not me." Something shifted in Odessa's voice then, something Simone was moving too fast to catch, a small crack of a door that opened and then, just as quickly, closed again before either of them could walk through it. "I raised you not to be. Doesn't mean I don't worry."

"I don't need you to worry, I need the Hebert check to clear."

"Then call Hebert instead of me. I can't make his check clear, baby, all I can do is tell you what I already told you." Odessa exhaled, the sound of a woman letting go of an argument she knew wasn't going anywhere productive. "You eating?"

"I'm eating."

"Mm-hm." The same sound Pearline made. The same disbelief, worn by two different women who had both, in their own ways, spent decades keeping other people fed while nobody much asked if they had. "Call me when it clears."

"I will."

Simone hung up and stood there another minute, phone warm in her hand, the eggs a total loss now, and felt the specific shame of having been parented at seven in the morning by a woman who was, once again, entirely correct. She scraped the pan into the trash and started over, and by the time Isaiah wandered into the kitchen in his school clothes asking if there was anything besides eggs because he was "kind of over eggs, no offense," she had already

built the whole plan in her head - real accounts, a hard line between business and household, an actual buffer this time instead of a hope wearing the coat of a buffer - certain, as she made him cereal instead, that discipline about her accounts was the fix, the actual fix, finally, and did not let herself sit for even a second with the small crack that had opened in her mother's voice and shut again just as fast, the eleven months, the job Odessa hated for six years, the two children who needed shoes, because Simone had a nine a.m. and a bank to call and no room this morning for anything that wasn't, strictly, actionable.

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CHAPTER 6

Chapter Six: Renata's Email

The email arrived at 8:52 a.m., subject line "Following up," which in Renata's particular dialect meant something closer to I would like it noted, in writing, that I was right.

Simone read it twice at her desk at Meridian, the small windowless office she shared with a ficus that was dying by inches no matter how religiously she watered it, and felt the specific heat crawl up the back of her neck that Renata's emails always produced, a heat that had nothing to do with the actual content, which was, if she was honest, mostly reasonable.

Wanted to flag that the Hebert deliverables timeline has slipped again - this is the third instance this quarter. Happy to discuss whether we need to reallocate the account.

Cc'd: their director. Of course. Renata did not do private conversations when a public one could accomplish the same correction with an audience attached.

Simone typed four different responses and deleted three of them. The one she sent was measured, professional, the kind of email that would read, to anyone skimming it, as perfectly composed - Appreciate the flag, I'm addressing the Hebert timeline directly this week, will have an update by Friday - and cost her, in the composing, roughly the same energy as writing the actual bank presentation had.

She saw Renata in the break room an hour later, at the counter, waiting on the ancient Keurig that took forty seconds to warm up and that everyone on the floor had strong, specific opinions about. Renata didn't look up.

"Got your email," Simone said, aiming for light and landing somewhere closer to clipped.

"I figured you would." Renata's voice was even, unbothered, the voice of a woman who had made peace a long time ago with not being liked in exchange for being unquestionably competent. "I wasn't trying to embarrass you. I was trying to protect the account before the client notices before we do."

"You cc'd Denise."

"Denise needed to know regardless of who told her." Renata pulled her mug out from under the machine, finally looked over, and there was nothing in her expression that read as triumph, which was somehow more irritating than if there had been. "I'm not your enemy, Simone."

"I didn't say you were."

"You didn't have to." Renata took a sip, winced - the coffee was, as always, terrible - and started to go, then paused at the door, half turned. "For what it's worth. I know you're building something outside of here. I don't hold that against you. I just can't be the one covering when it costs the client."

She left before Simone could construct a response to that, which was probably intentional, Renata's particular gift for ending a conversation exactly at the point where she'd said the thing she meant to say and nothing more.

Simone stood in the break room a minute, coffee she hadn't wanted going cold in her own hand, running the whole exchange through the part of her brain that ran everything through a kind of forensic replay - what she should have said, what she'd said instead, whether the silence at the end had cost her something. She'd built a whole private theory of Renata over three years at Meridian: cold, territorial, the kind of colleague who mistook rigor for a personality. It was a tidy theory. It required nothing further of her except vigilance.

It was 5:40 that evening, the office mostly emptied out, when Simone came back for a folder she'd left on her desk and passed Renata's office on the way, door cracked, lights still on. Renata was at her desk eating from a plastic container, alone, the particular posture of someone eating a meal at a desk not because they were busy but because there was nowhere else, particularly, to be - no group heading out, no one popping in to ask if she wanted to grab something - just Renata and a container of something reheated and a laptop screen throwing pale light across a face that, for once,

wasn't arranging itself into the composed unbotheredness she wore like a second blazer.

Simone didn't stop. Didn't say anything. There wasn't a version of stopping that wouldn't have felt like an intrusion, or worse, like pity, which Renata would have hated more than the cold coffee. She just noticed it, the way you notice a light left on in a house you're driving past, filed it without deciding what to do with it, and kept walking to her own office for the folder.

On the drive home she rehearsed, out of old habit, the case for escalating - she could go to Denise herself, get ahead of Renata's framing, make sure her own version of the Hebert timeline landed first. It was the kind of move she was good at, the kind that had gotten her exactly as far as she'd gotten. She thought about it the whole length of Perkins Road, turning it over, weighing it, and somewhere around the light at Acadian she decided, for no reason she examined too closely, not to. She'd handle the timeline. She wouldn't escalate. It felt, she told herself, like restraint, like the mature call, like something Odessa would approve of if Odessa knew the players involved, which she didn't, and didn't need to.

She did not think about the plastic container, or the empty office around it, or what it might cost a person to eat alone in a lit room on a night when everyone else in the building had somewhere to be, because by the time she pulled into her own driveway Isaiah was already at the window watching for her, and the eggs from the disastrous morning had somehow become tonight's dinner too, reheated, and there was a whole rest of the evening waiting that had nothing to do with Renata at all.

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Chapter Seven: Zay's Science Fair

The gymnasium smelled like every school gymnasium in Baton Rouge smelled - floor wax and construction paper and the specific mustiness of an air conditioning unit fighting a losing battle against two hundred parents in September - and Simone arrived at 6:47 for a 6:00 start, heels clicking too loud across the shining floor, a folder of Thursday's revised numbers still tucked under one arm because she had told herself she'd review them in the car line and had not, in fact, reviewed them in the car line.

She found Isaiah's table in the third row. Baking soda volcano - his choice, not the most original idea in the room, flanked on either side by a solar oven and something involving plant growth under colored light that had clearly benefited from a parent's Saturday afternoon - and Isaiah standing beside it in his good shirt, the one Odessa had bought him for Easter, arms crossed, not looking at the volcano, looking at the door.

"Hey, baby, I'm here, I'm so sorry, the meeting ran-

"It already erupted." He said it flatly, not looking at her, still looking somewhere past her shoulder like he was checking to see if there was a version of her that might have arrived on time hiding behind the real one. "Like twenty minutes ago. Mr. Guidry already came by and graded it and everything."

"I'm sorry, Zay. I really am, I got stuck-

"It's fine." The particular flatness of a ten-year-old's it's fine, which meant almost precisely the opposite, a flatness she recognized because she'd been using the exact same tone on other people all

week.

"Show me anyway. I want to see it."

"You can't see it, it already happened, that's what erupting means." He said this with more heat than the sentence needed, and a woman standing at the next table over - the solar oven mother - glanced over with the particular sympathetic wince of somebody who recognized a fight not going anywhere good and wanted no part of it.

"Isaiah."

"You said you'd be here at six."

"I know what I said."

"You always say a time and then it's not the time." He wasn't crying. He was worse than crying, he was performing a kind of contained, dignified disappointment that he'd clearly practiced on smaller occasions and was now deploying at full scale, arms still crossed, chin up, refusing to give her the satisfaction of a reaction she could apologize her way out of. "Renata's daughter's mom got here at 5:30. She helped her set up early."

"This isn't a competition with Renata's daughter's mom."

"I didn't say it was a competition. I said she got here at 5:30." He shrugged, a gesture that on a grown man would have read as contempt and on a ten-year-old read as something closer to grief with nowhere yet to go. "It's fine, Mama. It already erupted. It's just baking soda and vinegar, it's not that deep."

He walked off toward the snack table before she could answer, weaving between a line of second graders clutching juice boxes,

and Simone stood alone at his table looking down at the volcano - construction-paper mountain gone gray and crusted from its one performance, a small hand-lettered card propped beside it that read HYPOTHESIS: I think it will erupt because baking soda and vinegar make a chemical reaction, in Isaiah's careful, effortful ten-year-old print, the letters getting slightly larger toward the end of the sentence the way they always did when he ran out of room to plan ahead.

She read it twice. I think it will erupt. He'd been so sure of it, confident enough to write it down in advance, and she had missed the only part that mattered, the part where the thing he'd hypothesized actually came true and there'd been nobody in the audience who was supposed to be there to see it land.

Mr. Guidry came by a few minutes later, saw her standing alone at the table, and made kind, generic conversation about baking soda volcanoes being a science fair staple for good reason, reliable, satisfying, a crowd-pleaser even when the crowd showed up late. She thanked him. She did not tell him that the crowd he meant was one person, and that the one person had been in a parking lot on Airline Highway forty minutes ago telling herself the meeting couldn't be helped, which had been true, and was somehow also, entirely, beside the point.

She found Isaiah again by the snack table, a paper cup of red punch in one hand, talking to a friend with the specific unbothered ease kids have of setting a bad feeling down the second something better walks by. He saw her coming and the ease didn't quite leave his face, but something in his shoulders braced, a small defensive posture she recognized because she'd been wearing a version of it

herself all week.

"You want to show me how it works? Even if it already happened? I bet you could tell me better than watching it anyway."

He considered this with the seriousness of a boy deciding whether an apology was sufficient collateral for reopening a wound. "It's baking soda and vinegar. The vinegar's an acid and the baking soda's a base and when they touch they make carbon dioxide, that's the bubbles, that's the eruption."

"That's it? That simple?"

"Most stuff that looks big is just two small things that weren't supposed to touch, touching," he said, entirely unaware of having said anything beyond the assigned chemistry, already reaching past her for a second cup of punch, already three thoughts ahead, already, mercifully, most of the way back to fine.

She laughed - she couldn't help it, the sentence landing somewhere in her chest a half-second after it left his mouth - and he looked at her, confused, punch halfway to his lips.

"What's funny?"

"Nothing, baby. You're just smart."

"I know," he said, entirely without irony, and wandered back toward his friend, and Simone stood there a moment longer in a gymnasium that smelled like floor wax, holding a folder of numbers she still hadn't reviewed, thinking that she would build a better system for this - a shared calendar, alerts, a hard rule about leaving fifteen minutes earlier than felt necessary for exactly this kind of thing - certain that the problem tonight had been logistics,

timing, a meeting that ran long, a fixable gap in her scheduling discipline, and did not let herself sit, not yet, not this Tuesday, with the particular look on his face when she'd first walked up to that table, the one that hadn't been about the volcano at all.

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CHAPTER 8

Chapter Eight: The Porch Story

It rained that evening, a short hard summer rain that came and went in twenty minutes the way Louisiana rain did, leaving the whole street steaming faintly under the streetlights, and by the time Simone walked over - Isaiah at a sleepover, an actual free evening, rare enough that she almost didn't know what to do with it besides walk toward the one porch that had always known what to do with her - Pearline was already out there, chair pulled a little closer to the rail than usual, watching the water still dripping off the gutter in a steady, unhurried rhythm.

"You're out here without a kid tonight," Pearline said. "That's a novelty."

"He's at a sleepover. I didn't know what to do with myself so I walked here."

"Smartest thing you've done all week, probably." Pearline nodded at the empty rocker, and Simone sat, and for a while neither of them said much, just watched the street go from wet-dark to wet-glistening as the rain finished clearing out and a little moon came up over the Robicheaux roofline.

"You ever hear from your daughter?" Simone asked it carefully, the memory of the last time still sitting somewhere in her, the quick cloud that had passed over Pearline's face and gone. She hadn't meant to ask it again so soon. It came out anyway, the way things did on porches like this one.

Pearline didn't answer right away. She reached for her tea, found it empty, set it back down without seeming to notice.

"She called Sunday," Pearline said finally. "Ten minutes. Told me about a promotion. I congratulated her. Then we ran out of things to say and she had to go get her kids from somewhere." She said it evenly, the way she said everything, but there was something underneath the evenness tonight, some seam that usually stayed stitched shut and had come a little loose in the rain.

"That's more than nothing."

"It's ten minutes." Pearline looked out at the street a while longer. "You want to know something I don't tell people. I'm the reason she left the way she did. Not Houston. Houston's just Houston, plenty of people move there and call their mamas every Sunday like clockwork. I mean the way she left - quick, quiet, didn't say goodbye right, packed half her room in the middle of the night like she was escaping something."

"What was she escaping?"

"Me telling her, every single day of her life, that dreaming too big was how you ended up disappointed, and disappointment was the one thing this family couldn't afford." Pearline's voice didn't shake. It just got very quiet, the porch quiet, the after-rain quiet, the kind that made you lean in without meaning to. "I told her that because

it was true for me. I wanted to sing, you know that? Real singing, church choir was just where I started, I had people telling me I ought to try Nashville, try somewhere, and I had a baby at nineteen and a husband who thought ambition in a woman was a kind of disrespect, and so I put it down. Put the whole thing down like you'd put down a hot pan, quick, before it could burn me worse than it already had. And then I spent the next twenty years telling my daughter, every chance I got, to be sensible. To be safe. To not want too much out loud, because wanting too much out loud is how the Lord and everybody else finds out you're disappointed when it doesn't come."

Simone sat very still. The rain had left the porch smelling like wet concrete and cut grass, a smell she'd have recognized blind, and somewhere under it she could feel something moving in her own chest that she didn't have a name for yet, something that had less to do with Pearline's daughter and more to do with a version of the same sermon she'd been collecting off this porch for years, filing away as gospel.

"She wasn't running from Baton Rouge," Pearline said. "She was running from a woman who couldn't stand to watch her want things, because the wanting reminded me of everything I'd already decided not to want anymore." She let out a breath that was almost a laugh, almost, but not quite landing there. "And now I sit out here and tell every young woman who walks by my porch about discipline. Get up. Do the thing. Don't wait to feel like it. And half the time I believe every word of it. And the other half I know good and well I'm just telling somebody else's daughter the same thing that ran my own daughter clean out of the state."

"You don't have to carry that."

"I know I don't have to. I do anyway. That's what regret is, baby - it's not required, it's just persistent." Pearline reached for the tea again, found it empty again, this time noticed, and let out a real laugh this time, short, surprised at herself. "Look at me. Crying into an empty glass like that's going to refill it."

"You're not crying."

"Close enough for government work." Pearline wiped under one eye with the back of her wrist, quick, almost businesslike, and by the time her hand came back down she had mostly reassembled herself, the porch-sermon woman sliding back over the other one like a screen door easing shut. "Don't you go feeling sorry for me now. I had a good life. I raised two children who mostly turned out fine. I'm just telling you because you asked, and because you're sitting on my porch collecting my sayings like they're scripture, and I think it's about time you knew where a few of them actually came from."

Simone reached over without entirely deciding to and put her hand over Pearline's, the way you'd steady something that had wobbled but not fallen. "Thank you for telling me."

"Don't thank me. Just-" Pearline paused, looking for the words, and for once didn't find a clean sermon to hand over, just something rougher, truer, less finished. "Just don't take everything I say for law, is all. Some of what I know is wisdom. Some of it's just an old woman still arguing with her own life through other people's daughters. You're going to have to learn to tell them apart yourself, because Lord knows I never fully learned it, and I'm seventy-one."

They sat a while longer without saying much else, the street drying out under the streetlights, and Simone walked home a little after nine with her arms crossed against the cooling air, turning something over that she couldn't quite get a grip on - not a lesson, not yet, nothing so tidy as that, just a loose thread that had come untucked from a sermon she'd been wearing for years without ever checking the label, and a small, unfamiliar question that followed her the whole six blocks home and didn't announce itself as anything more than a question: how much of what I believe about myself did I actually decide, and how much of it did I just inherit from somebody else's unfinished argument with their own life.

She didn't answer it that night. She got home, checked on the empty house, poured a glass of water she didn't really want, and went to bed earlier than she had in weeks, the question still sitting somewhere in the room with her, patient, unresolved, willing to wait.

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CHAPTER 9

Chapter Nine: What Neecy Almost Said

Neecy's apartment always smelled like whatever candle was currently winning her rotating loyalty - this month it was something called "Sugared Fig," burning on the coffee table next to a bottle of wine that was two-thirds gone between them - and it was well past eleven, later than either of them usually stayed up on a work night, both of them on the couch with their shoes off, the TV on but muted, some cooking competition neither of them was

actually watching.

"I'm serious, if I have to do one more root canal billing code I'm gonna set the office on fire," Neecy said, refilling her glass, not Simone's, a small unconscious math she always did, more for herself lately, though Simone hadn't clocked why. "Like, ten years, Sim. Ten years of root canal billing codes. You know how many root canals that is?"

"A lot of root canals."

"A biblical amount of root canals." Neecy laughed, but it came out a half-beat off from her usual laugh, shorter, without the follow-through. She looked at the muted TV a second, at a man frosting a cake with an intensity that suggested his whole life depended on it, and said, quieter, not really looking at Simone when she said it, "I had a whole plan, you remember? Cosmetology school. I was gonna do hair for a living, real hair, not this- " she gestured vaguely at herself, at the room, at the candle, at nothing in particular and everything at once. "I was gonna open my own shop. I used to draw the floor plan on notebook paper in eleventh grade."

"I remember. You had it all - the chairs, the wash stations, you had a name for it."

"Crown and Glory." Neecy said the name like it belonged to somebody else now, a stranger she used to know well. "I still think about that name sometimes. Isn't that stupid? Thirty-four years old thinking about a name I made up when I was sixteen."

"It's not stupid."

"It's a little stupid." Neecy took a sip, longer than the sentence

needed. "I keep telling myself I'm gonna do it. Every year I tell myself this is the year, I'm gonna save up, take the classes, do the thing. And then it's not the year. It's never the year. And I'm starting to think-" She stopped herself right there, right at the edge of it, the way a person stops right before a curb they've clocked half a second too late to fully avoid stepping off of.

"Starting to think what?"

"Nothing. I'm being dramatic, it's the wine." Neecy laughed again, working harder at it this time, reaching for the remote to unmute the TV like the sound might fill the space she'd almost opened. "Ooh, look, he's putting the fondant on wrong, that's gonna collapse, I called it-"

"Neecy."

"What."

"You didn't finish."

Neecy's thumb hovered over the volume button. For a second something in her face went very still, very unguarded, the exact opposite of the room she usually walked into - no Charger muffler, no announcement, no shoes held out like a challenge - just a woman on her own couch at eleven-thirty on a Tuesday looking, for once, like she'd run out of jokes to put between herself and the thing she was about to say.

"I think I've waited too long," she said, quiet, fast, like she was trying to get the sentence out before she could stop it. "I think I kept saying this year for so many years that I turned it into a bit. Like it's not even a real plan anymore, it's just a thing Neecy says, everybody expects it, ha ha, there she goes again, Crown and

Glory, sure, Neecy, sure." She wasn't looking at Simone. She was looking at the muted cake collapsing exactly the way she'd predicted. "And I think if I actually tried and it didn't work, I could survive that. I really think I could. But I don't know if I can survive finding out I waited so long there's nothing left to try for. That the version of me who could've done it easy, when it was just courage standing in the way and not also, like, a mortgage and a body that doesn't bounce back the way it used to and-"

She stopped. Reached for the remote again, thumb actually pressing it this time, and the TV filled with the sound of a judge saying something enthusiastic about buttercream, and Neecy laughed, bright, a little too bright, already three sentences past the thing she'd just said. "Anyway. Ignore me. I'm being a whole Lifetime movie right now, it's the wine, I promise I'm fine, I'm always fine, that's my whole brand."

Simone opened her mouth to respond and felt, in the half-second before she spoke, the specific pull of every instinct she trusted - fix it, solve it, hand Neecy a plan the way she'd hand a client a plan, a timeline, a first concrete step, cosmetology school enrollment deadlines, a budget breakdown, the practical machinery she was good at building for other people's dreams. "Okay, but for real - what if we actually looked at the numbers? I bet the classes aren't as expensive as you think, and if you did nights while keeping the billing job-"

"Sim." Neecy said it gently, but it landed like a hand on the wrist. "I don't need a spreadsheet right now."

"I wasn't trying to-"

"I know you weren't. That's just what you do. Somebody hands you

a feeling and you hand them back a plan." Neecy said it without any real edge, more amused than hurt, but something in it stuck to Simone anyway, lodged somewhere she couldn't immediately locate. "I just wanted to say it out loud one time to somebody who wouldn't try to fix it before I finished saying it."

"I'm sorry."

"You don't have to be sorry. You just have to sit here." Neecy pulled her knees up onto the couch, tucked them under her, and reached for the remote to turn the volume back down instead of off entirely, so the cooking show became a soft, wordless background hum, and after a minute she leaned her head against Simone's shoulder, the way she'd done a thousand times since they were girls, and said nothing else about Crown and Glory, or the mortgage, or the body that didn't bounce back, and Simone sat there with Neecy's head on her shoulder and the muted-then-unmuted TV throwing pale light across the room, thinking - not about Neecy's fear, which had already retreated back behind its usual joke, but about her own hands, and the fact that the very first thing they'd reached for, the very first thing, had been a spreadsheet.

She didn't finish the thought that night either. She drove home a little after midnight with the windows cracked, the sugared-fig smell still faintly on her clothes, and lay awake longer than she meant to, turning over the sentence Neecy had handed her almost as an afterthought - somebody hands you a feeling and you hand them back a plan - not yet able to see it as anything other than a small, fair critique of a friend who cared too much about being useful, and not yet able to hear, underneath it, the sound of her own

name being called from somewhere she hadn't thought to look.

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CHAPTER 10

Chapter Ten: The Meeting She Almost Missed

The call came at 9:52, four minutes before the bank meeting was supposed to start, and Simone almost didn't answer it because the number was the school's front office, and the front office calling during a school day only ever meant one of two things, both of them bad.

"Miss Baptiste, this is Ms. Fontenot, Isaiah's running a fever, 101.4, he's in the clinic, he needs to be picked up."

She stood in the hallway outside the conference room at Gulf Coast Federal with her phone pressed hard against her ear and her laptop bag digging into her shoulder and the folder of numbers - finally, finally reviewed, finally right - tucked under her arm, and did the math out loud in her head before she could stop herself: fifteen minutes to the school, fifteen back, the meeting was forty-five minutes, there was no version of this arithmetic that worked, and somewhere behind the closed conference room door she could hear the loan officer's voice, cheerful, asking someone if they wanted coffee while they waited.

"I'm at a work thing, is there - can he wait twenty minutes, is there someone-"

"He's got a fever, ma'am, we really do need him picked up, that's

district policy above 100.4."

"Okay. Okay, I understand, I'm coming, just - is he okay, is he scared?"

"He's just tired, he's lying down, he'll be fine, we just need a parent."

Simone hung up and stood there in the hallway with the specific paralysis of a person facing two doors, both of them the wrong door, both of them a version of failing someone she loved. She thought about calling Odessa - twenty-five minutes away, no faster than she'd be herself. She thought about the deck in her hands, the twelve slides, the months of work, the entire reason the light bill situation existed in the first place, all of it sitting behind a door she was now going to have to walk through and immediately walk back out of.

She was already composing the apology in her head - family emergency, I'm so sorry, can we reschedule - already bracing for what that would cost her, when her phone buzzed again. A text, this time. Renata.

Heard about the school call from the front desk covering your calendar. I can present the Meridian portion and stall on the numbers slide until you're back. Go get him. Text me when you're in the car and I'll walk you through what I told them so we're aligned.

Simone read it twice, standing in the hallway, and felt something genuinely unfamiliar move through her - not relief exactly, relief was too simple a word for it, more like the specific disorientation of being caught by a net you didn't know was there.

"Okay," she typed back, thumbs clumsy. "Okay. Thank you. On my way."

She drove to the school faster than the speed limit strictly allowed, mind doing its usual ricochet between Isaiah's fever and the twelve slides now sitting in Renata's hands, a version of vulnerability she hadn't chosen and didn't have time to examine. Isaiah was in the clinic exactly as described, curled small on the little vinyl cot with the tissue-paper pillow, cheeks flushed, and the second he saw her his face did something that undid the entire morning in about half a second - not the wary, checking-the-clock face from the science fair, just plain relief, a ten-year-old's whole-body relief at the sight of his mother walking through a door.

"Hey, baby."

"I don't feel good."

"I know. I know, come here." She got a hand on his forehead, hot under her palm, and helped him up, one arm looped under his, the two of them shuffling slow toward the office to sign out while he leaned most of his weight against her side, not talking, just present, just needing to be carried the last twenty feet even though he was really too big for it now.

In the car, she texted Renata like she'd promised, and Renata's response came back fast, efficient, no commentary attached: Told them you had a family situation, kept it vague, presented the growth numbers, they had two questions I couldn't answer - cc'd you both, you can follow up tomorrow. Went fine. Hope he feels better.

Simone stared at the message at a red light on Perkins Road, Isaiah

asleep against the window beside her before they'd even gotten two miles, and felt the whole tidy theory of Renata she'd been building for three years develop a crack straight down the middle of it. This was not the behavior of a woman who wanted her account reallocated out from under her. This was not cold. This was, if Simone was being honest with herself in a way she generally reserved for other people's situations and not her own, something closer to grace, offered without announcement, without a cc to anyone who'd know to be impressed by it.

She got Isaiah home, got him into bed with a cool washcloth and children's Tylenol and a bucket positioned just in case, and sat on the edge of his bed a long while after he'd drifted off, watching him breathe, the fever making his cheeks blotchy and pink, one hand still loosely holding a stuffed dinosaur he hadn't slept with in probably two years but had apparently needed today.

The guilt came in the quiet then, and it didn't file away the way it usually did. Usually guilt like this arrived, got itself assigned a fixable cause - better scheduling, a backup plan for school emergencies, a clearer boundary between calendars - and got filed under things to improve. Tonight it just sat there instead, unassigned, refusing the paperwork. It wasn't really about the meeting. The meeting had gone fine, better than fine, because someone else had quietly held it up while she was somewhere else being needed more urgently. It wasn't really about the missed slide either. It was something underneath both of those things, something about the particular exhaustion of always being the one holding everything, and the strange, disorienting relief of finding out, for one Tuesday, that she hadn't had to.

She texted Renata again before bed. Thank you. I mean that. I owe you.

The reply came a few minutes later, short, characteristically unadorned. You don't. Go take care of your kid.

Simone put the phone face-down on the nightstand and lay there a while in the dark, listening for Isaiah's breathing through the cracked door, and did not reach, for once, for the usual explanation - the scheduling system, the backup plan, the discipline she'd fix next time - because for the first time all month, the thing she was feeling didn't seem to have a next-time fix waiting on the other side of it, and she fell asleep before she could figure out what did.

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CHAPTER 11

Chapter Eleven: Odessa's Kitchen

Sunday dinner at Odessa's had a liturgy to it that hadn't changed in twenty years - smothered chicken, rice that came out slightly different every week depending on Odessa's mood and nobody was allowed to comment on it, a green bean dish that was really just an excuse for bacon, and cousins drifting in and out of the kitchen all afternoon depending on who was fighting with whom that particular week.

Simone was drying dishes at the sink, Isaiah fully recovered and out back with two cousins engaged in some elaborate game involving a badminton racket and no birdie, when Odessa reached up to the top of the china cabinet for the good gravy boat, the one

that only came down for Sundays that mattered, and knocked loose an old photo tucked behind it, one Simone hadn't seen in years, maybe ever - Odessa, unmistakably young, in a choir robe far too big for her, standing next to a much younger Pearline in front of a church Simone didn't recognize.

"Mama, is this you?"

Odessa glanced at it, and something crossed her face too quick to name before she reached for it, almost took it, then let her hand drop instead, leaving it on the counter between them.

"Nineteen seventy-one. First Baptist, before they moved buildings." She went back to the gravy, businesslike, but her voice had lost its usual efficiency. "I was seventeen there."

"You look happy."

"I was happy. Choir made me happy." Odessa set the gravy boat down harder than it needed, and stood there a second with both hands flat on the counter, and Simone recognized, with the sudden clarity of a person noticing a familiar room from an angle they'd never stood in before, that her mother was deciding something.

"You never told me you sang."

"Wasn't much to tell. Everybody sang. It was church." Odessa picked the photo back up, looked at it a while longer than the sentence suggested she would. "I had a scholarship offer. Xavier, for the music program. Nineteen seventy-two."

Simone put the dish towel down. "You never told me that either."

"Wasn't relevant to tell you before now, I suppose." Odessa's jaw did the thing it did when she was working hard to keep her voice

level. "Your grandfather got sick that spring. Real sick, the kind that doesn't get better. And there was me and your uncle Ray, and somebody had to help hold the house together while your grandmother worked doubles at the hospital, and I was the oldest, and Xavier wasn't going anywhere I could get home from easy on a Sunday to help." She set the photo down flat on the counter, gently this time, like it might bruise. "So I gave the scholarship to a girl named Carletta Fontenot, who I have hated, quietly, in my heart, for fifty-some years, entirely without her ever knowing it or deserving it, because she went and had the life I was supposed to have and came home famous enough in this town that everybody still asks about her at my own kitchen table."

"Mama."

"I'm not telling you this for sympathy, Simone. I'm telling you because I watch you build this business of yours, and staying up till one in the morning, and running yourself down to nothing, and I keep hearing myself say get a real job, get something steady, and I know how that sounds coming out of my mouth. Like I don't believe in you. Like I think you're being foolish." Odessa turned to face her fully now, hands still damp from the sink, and there was something in her expression Simone had genuinely never seen there before, something unguarded, something that looked almost like asking for permission. "That's not what it is. What it is, is I gave up the one thing I ever wanted for myself so young I didn't even get to grieve it right, I just went straight from wanting it to being needed elsewhere, no space in between for the loss to land. And every single time I watch you chase this thing you want so bad you'd go without sleep for it, some old, ugly part of me gets scared for you and jealous of you in the very same breath, and I

don't know how to tell the two apart most days, so it all just comes out sounding like be careful, be safe, get something steady."

The kitchen was quiet except for the sound of Isaiah's laughter drifting in from the backyard, high and unbothered, chasing a badminton racket around a game with no rules Simone had ever been able to follow.

"I always thought you didn't believe in Ascend," Simone said, quiet.

"I believe in it plenty. I just don't know how to watch you want something that hard without my whole body remembering what it cost me the one time I wanted something that hard and couldn't have it." Odessa picked the photo back up, held it a second longer, then set it gently in Simone's hand instead of her own pocket, which Simone understood, without being told, to be a kind of gift. "Keep that. I don't need to look at Carletta Fontenot's better life every time I clean that cabinet."

Simone laughed - she couldn't help it, the sudden, dry turn of it exactly her mother's humor, planted in her whether she'd meant to inherit it or not - and Odessa almost smiled, the corner of her mouth doing the thing it did when she was trying to stay stern about something she no longer entirely believed in staying stern about.

"I'm sorry you didn't get to go," Simone said.

"I'm not looking for sorry. Sorry doesn't refund a scholarship." Odessa turned back to the gravy, capable again, businesslike again, the door that had opened easing most of the way shut but not, Simone noticed, all the way. "I'm looking for you to hear me

different than you've been hearing me. When I say be careful, hear I love you and I am terrified, not I don't believe in you. Those are two different sentences wearing the same coat, and I have been bad, apparently, at telling you which one you were getting."

"I'll try."

"That's all I'm asking. Now go tell your son to stop hitting his cousin with that racket before somebody loses an eye, and come set the table, this chicken's not going to smother itself onto plates."

Simone slipped the photograph into her back pocket and went out to the yard, and something in her chest had shifted position, not fixed, not resolved, just moved to a slightly different place than it had occupied that morning - her mother's caution reframed, for the first time in thirty-four years, not as doubt in her but as an old, unhealed love standing guard over a wound Simone had never known existed, and she carried that reframing through the rest of the meal without once turning it toward herself, without once asking the question that photograph was quietly, patiently waiting for her to ask about her own kitchen, her own cabinets, her own carefully guarded things.

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CHAPTER 12

Chapter Twelve: The Broken Heel

The Chamber's small business showcase was held in the old converted warehouse space off Third Street, the kind of building that had been a feed store and then nothing and then, eventually,

exposed brick and string lights and a name like The Foundry, and Simone had exactly six minutes to present Ascend to a room of maybe eighty people, most of them holding small plastic cups of wine, none of whom particularly cared, and one of whom - sitting in the third row, in his good shirt again, legs swinging because the chair was too tall for him - cared more than anyone else in the building.

Isaiah was only there because the sitter had canceled at four, and Neecy had offered to take him, and then Neecy's car had made a noise on the way over that neither of them liked the sound of, so in the end it had just seemed simpler to bring him, prop him up with a juice box and a promise of ice cream after, and let him watch his mother do the thing she did.

It had been, by any honest accounting, a long month wearing a long week wearing a long day. The Hebert account had finally cleared but had taken two other invoices down with it in the process. Isaiah's fever had turned into a stomach thing that turned into a full week of missed school and missed work both. The bank had asked for revised projections twice. She had slept, by her own rough count, somewhere south of five hours a night for eleven straight nights, and she stood backstage in the string-lit dark behind the little makeshift stage in heels she'd bought three years ago and hadn't replaced because replacing them had never once made it to the top of any list, running her six minutes through her head one more time, certain, the way she was always certain right before something, that if she could just hold the next six minutes together, everything underneath them could stay held too.

She walked out. The room clapped, politely, the particular

applause of people who clap for everyone at these things. She made it four steps toward the small riser at the center of the space.

The heel didn't so much break as give up entirely, the sole separating from the shaft with a small definitive crack, and her ankle went sideways into the gap where a floor grate met the old warehouse concrete, and she went down - not dramatically, not a full collapse, just a hard, graceless stumble, one hand slapping flat against the brick wall to catch herself, the folder of slides she'd been holding scattering three sheets of paper across the floor in a fan.

The room made the sound rooms make - a collective intake, a few nervous laughs, someone's chair scraping back like they meant to help and then didn't quite. Simone stayed there a second with her hand on the wall, ankle throbbing, heel snapped clean off and sitting a foot away from her like a small dead thing, and felt something in her chest do the same thing the shoe had just done - give up entirely, all at once, no warning, after holding on for far longer than it had any structural right to.

She meant to laugh it off. She had the sentence ready, the professional-woman recovery sentence, well, that's one way to make an entrance, the kind of line that would get the room laughing with her instead of at her and let her limp to the podium with her dignity mostly intact. She opened her mouth to say it.

What came out instead was nothing. Just breath, ragged, and then, humiliatingly, unstoppably, tears - not decorative tears, not the kind you could blink back into place with enough composure, but the real thing, ugly and fast, right there on the concrete floor of a converted feed store in front of eighty strangers holding plastic

wine cups.

She heard herself make a sound she didn't recognize, something between a laugh and a sob, and thought, distantly, from somewhere just outside her own body, this is the thing. This is the exact thing. This is everyone seeing me unfinished, right here, on the floor, in front of my son, and the thought itself made it worse, made the crying come harder, because now she was crying about crying, caught in the particular spiral of a woman who had spent her whole adult life making sure this specific scene never happened and was now living directly inside it with no exit she could see.

"Okay, everybody, show's over, nothing to see, she's fine, she does this every Tuesday-" Neecy's voice arrived before Neecy did, already moving through the crowd with the particular loud confidence that could make a room laugh on command, and she crouched down next to Simone on the concrete, not fixing her hair, not smoothing anything over, just crouched right there in her own good dress and put an arm around her. "Girl, of all the ways to make an exit. You couldn't have just tripped on the stairs like a normal person having a breakdown?"

Simone laughed - a real laugh, wet and broken and tangled up completely with the crying, the two sounds coming out of her at the same time in a way that felt, for the first time in longer than she could remember, entirely honest.

"My shoe broke," she managed.

"Baby, your whole self broke, the shoe's just the part you can see." Neecy said it low, just for her, not unkind, and helped her get a hand under her other arm, and somewhere in the small commotion Simone became aware of a second, smaller presence pushing

through legs and plastic cups toward her - Isaiah, out of his chair, juice box abandoned, working his way to the front with the single-minded determination of a boy who did not care one bit about eighty strangers or a showcase or slides scattered across the floor, who cared about exactly one thing, which was that his mother was on the ground.

He didn't say anything when he got to her. He didn't ask if she was okay, didn't perform concern the way an adult might have, just sat down next to her on the cold concrete floor in his good shirt, right there in front of everyone, and put his head against her shoulder the way he used to when he was much smaller, and stayed there.

She looked down at him. He looked up at her, not scared, not embarrassed, just present, the particular unguarded steadiness kids have when they haven't yet learned that a crying adult is supposed to be a crisis instead of just a thing that's happening.

"I'm okay, baby."

"You don't have to be okay," he said, matter-of-fact, already reaching for one of the fallen slide sheets to hand back to her, straightening it against his knee first like the small tidying gesture might help something. "You can just be however you are."

It landed nowhere near as loud as it should have. He said it the way he said everything, half-distracted, already looking around for where his abandoned juice box had gone, no idea he'd said anything at all, and Simone sat there on the concrete with her broken shoe and her ruined mascara and her son's head against her shoulder and eighty strangers slowly, politely returning to their own conversations to give her the dignity of being unwatched, and felt, for one long unguarded second, the entire architecture of the

last eleven months - the discipline, the schedules, the sticky notes, the five a.m. plans that never held, all of it built on the same quiet, unexamined terror - come into view all at once, whole, unmistakable, the way a shape in fog resolves the instant you stop straining to see it and just let your eyes go soft.

She had not been afraid of running out of time. She had not been afraid of the money, or Renata, or her own discipline. She had been afraid, this entire time, of exactly this - of being caught, in public, unfinished, with her shoe broken and her face wrecked and nothing left in reserve to perform with - and now that it had happened, now that the very worst version of the thing she'd spent a lifetime avoiding was sitting on a concrete floor actually occurring, in real time, in front of her son and her best friend and a room full of people holding plastic wine cups, she found, underneath the humiliation, something she had not expected to find there at all.

She was still loved. Nobody had left. Neecy's arm was still around her. Isaiah's head was still on her shoulder, patiently handing her slides he'd straightened against his knee. The room hadn't collapsed. The world had not, in fact, ended, the way some old unnamed part of her had apparently believed it would if anyone ever saw the seams.

"Come on," Neecy said, standing, pulling Simone up with her, careful of the ankle. "Let's get you somewhere with actual chairs and a shoe situation that isn't a public health hazard."

"I had a whole presentation."

"Baby, you gave a better one than the one in that folder. Nobody in this room's gonna remember a single slide. They're gonna remember the woman who fell down and laughed about it and got

carried off by her kid and her best friend like Cleopatra on a very cheap barge." Neecy was already steering her toward the side door, one arm still firm around her waist, and Isaiah trailed behind carrying the folder of straightened slides like it was cargo he'd personally been assigned to protect. "That's a better pitch than any twelve slides. That's a whole personality. You should charge extra for that."

Simone laughed again, the sound clearer now, less tangled, and let herself be walked - actually let herself, no argument, no reaching for the folder to review one more time in the car - out into the cooling evening air, one shoe on, one shoe carried, her son's hand finding hers without either of them deciding it, and did not, for once, reach for the next plan, the next discipline, the next fixable thing. She just let herself be exactly as unfinished as she currently was, walking slowly across a parking lot with the two people who had already, it turned out, seen everything there was to see, and had not gone anywhere.

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CHAPTER 13

Chapter Thirteen: What Neecy Never Said

They were back on Neecy's couch a week later, no candle burning this time, no wine either, just a bag of chips between them and a rerun of something neither of them was following closely, Simone's ankle still faintly tender in its brace, propped up on the coffee table.

"You've been different," Neecy said, out of nowhere, not looking

away from the TV, in the offhand way she said the things she'd actually been thinking about for a while. "Since the shoe thing."

"Different how?"

"I don't know. Softer. Like somebody let some air out of you and it turns out that was a good thing." Neecy reached for a chip, considered it, put it back. "You laugh different now. Like all the way instead of half-guarding it."

Simone thought about that a second, about whether it was true, and found, turning it over, that it probably was - some tight, load-bearing thing in her had shifted position since the concrete floor of The Foundry, some grip she hadn't known she was maintaining had eased without her deciding to ease it, and the world had, so far, gone on being entirely survivable in its absence.

"Can I say something," Simone said, "and you don't get to laugh it off before I finish."

Neecy went very still, the particular stillness of a person who has heard this exact sentence structure aimed at her before and knows, on some level, what direction it's about to go. "That's an ominous way to start a sentence."

"Crown and Glory," Simone said.

"Oh, we're doing this."

"We're doing this. You don't have to say anything. I just - I've been thinking about that night, and about the spreadsheet thing, and I think you were right, and I think I owe you actually sitting with it instead of trying to fix it." Simone kept her eyes on the muted TV, giving Neecy the same mercy Neecy always gave her, the option of

not having to hold eye contact through the hard part. "I don't think you're waiting because you're scared of trying and failing. I think you built a whole personality out of being the fun one, the one who shows up, the one who gets everybody else out of the house, and I think somewhere in there you decided that if you ever stopped being that on purpose to go chase Crown and Glory, you'd be letting everybody down who needs you to keep being fun. Including yourself. Especially yourself, probably, because being fun is easier to survive than wanting something and finding out you can't have it."

The TV kept talking to an empty room. Neecy didn't say anything for a long moment, and Simone let the silence sit there, uncrowded, the way Isaiah had let hers sit on the concrete floor, no reaching for a spreadsheet, no timeline, no next practical step waiting behind the sentence to make it useful.

"I hate that you're right," Neecy said finally, voice thick in a way she immediately tried to laugh off, and then, visibly, chose not to. "I hate it so much, Sim."

"I'm not trying to fix it."

"I know. That's what makes it worse. If you'd handed me a spreadsheet I could've made a joke and moved on." Neecy wiped under one eye, quick, the same gesture Pearline had made on her own porch, some inherited grammar of women who'd learned young not to let a feeling take up too much room. "I don't even know when it happened. The turning it into a bit. I think I just got tired of people asking about it and watching my face when I said 'this year' for the fifth year running, and it was easier to make it a joke before they could."

"You don't have to make it a joke with me."

"I know." Neecy leaned her head back against the couch cushion, looked at the ceiling a while. "I might not do it. Crown and Glory. I might get to the end of my life and never have done it, and I need you to know that's allowed too, that's not a tragedy waiting to happen, some people just don't get to the thing and they're still okay."

"That's allowed."

"But I also might do it." Neecy said this quieter, like she was testing the weight of the sentence out loud for the first time in years. "I looked up the classes last week. Didn't sign up for anything. Just looked."

"That's a start."

"Don't spreadsheet me right now."

"I'm not. I'm just saying it's a start, and then I'm gonna stop talking about it, and you can bring it up again whenever you bring it up again, if you bring it up again, and if you never do, I'm still gonna love you exactly the same amount."

Neecy turned and looked at her then, really looked, the teasing mostly gone out of her face for once, replaced with something unguarded and a little startled, like she hadn't expected the conversation to end anywhere but a punchline and didn't quite know what to do with the fact that it hadn't.

"When did you get like this?"

"Get like what?"

"Like - actually just sitting there. Not managing it." Neecy shook

her head, half a laugh in it now, easier. "It's kind of unsettling, honestly. I don't know if I like it."

"You like it."

"I like it a little." Neecy reached over and stole the last chip out of the bag, victorious about it in the particular way she was victorious about small food-related conquests, and the moment folded itself back into the ordinary evening it had briefly stepped out of - the muted TV, the empty chip bag, the two of them on a couch that had held a hundred ordinary Tuesdays like this one and would, in all likelihood, hold a hundred more.

Neither of them said anything else about Crown and Glory that night. It didn't need saying again, not right away - the sentence had landed where it needed to land and could sit there now, quiet, unrushed, the way a seed sits in the ground doing nothing visible for exactly as long as it needs to. Simone drove home a little after eleven with her ankle aching faintly in its brace, and thought, pulling into her own driveway, that she had done something tonight she couldn't remember doing before - she had told someone a hard true thing about themselves and then simply stopped, no plan attached, no fix offered, nothing to manage on either end, just the sentence, set down gently, and left there to be whatever it was going to be.

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CHAPTER 14

Chapter Fourteen: Ordinary Tuesday

Nothing happened on this particular Tuesday. That was, in the end, the whole thing worth saying about it.

Simone woke up at 6:40, not 5:00, because the alarm hadn't gone off and she hadn't set a backup, and instead of the small private panic that used to come with a lost forty minutes, she just lay there a second longer than she needed to, listening to Isaiah already up and moving around the kitchen, the particular clatter of a ten-year-old attempting to make his own toast and mostly succeeding.

She went to the Winn-Dixie after work, the same Winn-Dixie, the same fluorescent hum, and got the same cart she always seemed to get, the one with the wheel that pulled left and squeaked on every third rotation like it was complaining about something specific only it understood. She noticed it, the way she always noticed it, considered for half a second whether to swap it for another one by the entrance, and didn't, the way she never did, because she was already two aisles deep with a list only half-followed, and some imperfections just became part of how a person moved through a store, familiar enough by now to be almost comforting, evidence of a life that hadn't required perfect equipment to keep running.

Isaiah wanted the name-brand cereal again. She put it in the cart without the speech this time, without the two-seventy math running behind her eyes, and he didn't even seem to notice the absence of the argument, already three aisles ahead, negotiating string cheese with the same intensity as always, some things in a household staying reliably, wonderfully the same even while other things underneath them quietly rearranged themselves.

Renata texted about the Hebert account - resolved now, three

weeks clean, no further incidents - and added, at the end, almost as an afterthought, there's a happy hour thing some of us are doing Friday if you want to come, no pressure, just an invite. Simone looked at it a long moment in the parking lot before typing back I'd like that, surprised at how easily the sentence came, how little negotiating it required with the part of her that used to keep Renata neatly filed under obstacle instead of person eating alone in a lit office.

Pearline was on her porch when Simone walked Isaiah past on the way back from the store, and called them up same as always, and gave a whole sermon about the price of gas that had absolutely nothing to do with discipline or daughters or anything underneath the surface of it - just an old woman complaining about gas prices to anyone who'd sit still long enough to hear it, funny and light and entirely, blessedly ordinary, and Simone sat there and let it be exactly that, not mining it for a deeper lesson, just enjoying a woman she loved being cranky about gas.

Neecy called at eight, not to talk about Crown and Glory, just to complain about a difficult patient's mother and to ask if Simone had seen some video that was, apparently, sweeping the entire internet, and they talked for twenty minutes about nothing consequential at all, and it was, somehow, one of the best twenty minutes of Simone's week.

She didn't touch the deck that night. There wasn't one due. Thursday, for once, had nothing waiting on the other side of it that required tonight's sacrifice, and she noticed the absence of the familiar tightness in her chest that usually accompanied an open evening, the old reflex to fill it with something productive, and let

the evening stay open instead, unfilled, a little strange in its emptiness, mostly good.

Isaiah asked for the Wi-Fi password once, out of habit more than need, already knowing it, and she said it back to him - Sunflower, capital S, four four seven - without any edge in it at all, and he wandered off to watch something loud and ridiculous, and she sat on the couch with a book she'd been meaning to read for three months and actually opened it, actually stayed on the same page for longer than ninety seconds, actually let herself be a woman reading a book on a Tuesday night instead of a woman managing forty things while pretending to read a book.

She must have fallen asleep somewhere around page thirty. She didn't remember deciding to. She was still in her work clothes, the book open facedown on her chest, the lamp still on, when some small movement in the room pulled her half toward waking - not enough to surface all the way, just enough to register weight settling gently over her, a soft, familiar pull of fabric, the specific texture of the blanket that lived folded over the back of the couch, and a small set of hands working carefully, seriously, the particular concentration of a boy trying very hard not to wake his mother up.

She let her eyes open just enough to see him - Isaiah, tongue between his teeth in concentration, tucking the blanket in at her shoulder with the same seriousness he brought to a science fair hypothesis, the TV still on behind him, sound low, some cartoon flickering blue light across the room he clearly had no intention of leaving just because his mother had fallen asleep in the middle of the evening.

He looked up. Caught her watching him.

Neither of them said anything.

She smiled at him - small, unguarded, no performance left in it, nothing to explain or apologize for or fix - and he smiled back, quick and unremarkable, already turning back to the TV like tucking a blanket around a sleeping mother was simply what a Tuesday sometimes asked of a person and didn't require any further comment.

She closed her eyes again. Somewhere in the house the dishwasher hummed through its cycle, and somewhere further off a dog was barking at something that would stop mattering to it in another minute, and the blanket was warm, and her son was three feet away doing exactly what he wanted to do on an ordinary evening, needing nothing further from her than the simple fact of her sleeping there, unfinished, uncorrected, entirely at rest.

She went back to sleep.

Nothing else happened. That was the whole of it. That was, it turned out, more than enough.

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